

From Grievance to Representation? Migration-Related Discrimination, Political Voice, and MEP Responsiveness in Europe

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ABSTRACT

Across Europe, the representative link between citizens and elites is increasingly strained, particularly for groups whose grievances remain institutionalized or weakly articulated. Grounded in theories of descriptive representation and politicized grievance, this article investigates how migration-related discrimination enters legislative agendas. We test three hypotheses: first, that Members of the European Parliament (MEPs) with a migratory or racialized minority background prioritize ethnic discrimination issues; second, that discrimination grievances enter agendas when widespread and politically voiced by citizens; and third, that an interaction effect renders minority MEPs uniquely responsive to localized civic pressure. We employ a linked mass–elite design, combining European Social Survey data (Rounds 1–11) to measure national "claims-making pressure" with EUQuest data on written parliamentary questions. We cross-reference this with an original dataset tracking the migratory backgrounds of MEPs in the 8th and 9th legislatures. The findings reveal a decoupled architecture of representation: civic pressure exerts a minor, positive effect on all MEPs, whereas minority-background MEPs show a profoundly higher independent willingness to address anti-discrimination. Crucially, these two effects are entirely separate. While descriptive identity acts as a powerful internal agenda-setting engine, it operates in a separate orbit from external grassroots mobilization.

Keywords: political representation; citizen–elite disconnection; MEP responsiveness; descriptive representation; migration-related discrimination

Paper prepared for the Annual CAP Conference, Paris 17-19 June 2026.

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Introduction

Across contemporary European democracies, the representative link connecting citizens to political elites is under intense strain. This disconnect is particularly severe for historically marginalized populations, whose policy grievances are often weakly articulated within formal institutional arenas. While democratic theory assumes a responsive transmission belt where societal demands are picked up and championed by legislative actors, the reality for Europe's migrant and racialised minority populations is vastly more complex. Structural disadvantages, such as migration-relevant ethnic or religious discrimination, do not automatically trigger political action within institutional venues. Instead, the path from experiencing a grievance in daily life to seeing that grievance addressed on a parliamentary floor requires crossing two formidable thresholds: first, the collective politicisation of private discrimination into visible civic voice, and second, the willingness of legislative elites to act as institutional conduits for those claims.

Political science scholarship has traditionally analysed these two dimensions on separate tracks. On one side, theories of descriptive representation demonstrate that the physical presence of marginalised groups within legislative bodies fundamentally reshapes institutional agendas. Legislators from minority backgrounds often possess an internal, experiential "gyroscope" that drives them to champion civil rights issues out of intrinsic motivation, independent of broader party discipline. On the other side, social movement and public agenda-setting literatures emphasise external opportunity structures, arguing that policy elites only respond to raw grievances when those grievances are loudly collectivised through public acts of political claims-making, such as petitions or demonstrations. What remains strikingly unexamined is the potential synergy between these internal and external dynamics. Do descriptive representatives require an external, vocal signal from marginalised communities to legitimise their advocacy, or does their intrinsic motivation bypass public mobilisation altogether? Conversely, does grassroots civic pressure influence all legislators uniformly, or does it uniquely activate minority politicians who share the claimants' lived experiences?

This article addresses these questions by investigating the conditions under which migration-related discrimination enters legislative agendas. We test three competing expectations. First, that members of the European Parliament (MEPs) with a migratory or racialized minority background are systematically more likely to raise anti-discrimination issues due to identity-driven issue entrepreneurship. Second, that legislative attention to discrimination is driven by national context, rising when state-level discrimination is widespread and actively expressed through high levels of migrant political voice. Finally, we expect that an interaction effect exists where minority-background MEPs show heightened strategic sensitivity and institutional responsiveness to local claims-making pressures from their home member states.

To evaluate these hypotheses, we deploy a linked mass-elite research design that matches mass public survey trends with elite legislative behaviour across national and supranational levels. At the mass level, we pool eleven rounds of the European Social Survey (ESS) from 2002 to 2024 across 26 EU Member States and the United Kingdom. We use this data to build a novel, country-level contextual index of claims-making pressure, which captures the precise structural overlap where migrants both experience migration-relevant discrimination *and* actively deploy non-electoral political voice. At the elite level, we match these macro-societal contexts with the EUQuest dataset, tracking approximately 180,000 written parliamentary questions tabled in the European Parliament. Written questions serve as an ideal measure of individual representative intent because they face low institutional veto barriers and allow individual MEPs to act as policy entrepreneurs relatively unconstrained by group discipline. Crucially, we cross-reference this

legislative output with an original, hand-coded biographical dataset that tracks the first- and second-generation migratory and racialised minority backgrounds of all MEPs serving during the 8th and 9th legislatures (2014–2024).

Our findings reveal a complex, decoupled architecture of democratic representation that operates via what we conceptualize as "separate channels of representation". On one hand, external claims-making pressure functions as a modest informational signal: when marginalised communities are highly active and visible, they exert a small, positive pull on the propensity of *all* MEPs to table questions regarding ethnic discrimination, likely driven by universal electoral or normative cues. On the other hand, an MEP's personal biographical background operates as a massive internal engine. Controlling for all institutional features, political party families, and vital committee assignments, such as membership in the Civil Liberties, Justice and Home Affairs (LIBE) committee, minority-background MEPs exhibit a profoundly higher baseline propensity to raise anti-discrimination issues than their majority peers.

Crucially, however, our interaction tests yield a major theoretical paradox: these two channels operate in entirely separate orbits. Minority-background representatives do not require a loud, highly vocal domestic signal to prompt them into legislative action. Their intrinsic, experiential motivation provides a stable, continuous dedication to civil rights issues that functions independently of whether grassroots domestic constituencies are currently mobilized or quiet.

The first section outlines the theoretical framework leading to our hypotheses. Next, we discuss our strategy related to measuring our variables and modelling the data. After the data analysis and discussion, we discuss several limitations of this work that we regard as a still preliminary version.

Theoretical Framework: From gyroscopic representation to politicised grievances

A long-standing normative and empirical literature posits that the numerical presence of marginalized groups within legislative bodies fundamentally alters institutional outputs (Mansbridge, 1999). While traditional models of representation prioritise partisan discipline or district-level median voter incentives, a legislator's social background serves as an internal, intrinsic "gyroscope" that guides behavioural choices, independent of external strategic constraints (Burden, 2007). In a context of crystallised societal distrust and systemic exclusion, shared life experiences and socialisation do not merely create symbolic affinity; they function as cognitive lenses that alter how representatives prioritise policy issues (Sobolewska et al., 2018).

In the context of the European Parliament, this intrinsic motivation manifests as "issue entrepreneurship." Because transnational legislative agendas are vast and attention is a scarce resource, MEPs must selectively ration their legislative instruments, such as written parliamentary questions. Representatives who belong to migratory or racialised minorities carry experiential knowledge that lowers the information costs required to recognise systemic bias. Not only this, but they are more intrinsically motivated to defend the rights of those citizens coming from their background. Consequently, even within highly institutionalized assemblies where partisan identities are strong, an MEP's migratory background acts as an independent, internal engine for agenda-setting on civil rights and anti-discrimination.

H1: *Members of the European Parliament with a migratory background will be more likely to raise anti-discrimination issues in EP questions.*

While individual background provides an internal disposition to act, democratic representation is inherently relational, requiring a behavioral signal from the electorate. However, the transmission of marginalised group interests into institutional arenas is rarely automatic. Sociological scholarship establishes that raw, structural grievances, such as experiencing

migration-relevant discrimination, do not mechanically translate into legislative attention (Gurr, 1993; Tilly, 1978). For a structural disadvantage to cross the threshold into institutional politics, it must undergo a process of politicization, moving from a private experience of unfairness to a visible, public claim (Hay, 2013).

We conceptualize this dynamic as a function of civic claim-making pressure, which requires two simultaneous components: the structural prevalence of discrimination and the collective deployment of political voice. When individuals experiencing discrimination engage in visible political action (e.g., contacting officials, signing petitions, demonstrating), they externalize their grievances, turning private suffering into an observable, public problem. For policy elites, this vocal mobilization operates as an informational signal. High-visibility claims lower the diagnostic costs for representatives, rendering the issue of discrimination harder to overlook on the political periphery. Where discrimination is widespread but politically quiet, the signal fails, leaving grievances institutionally unrepresented.

H2: *Attention to discrimination-related issues by MEPs is expected to be higher in countries where migration-relevant discrimination among migrants is more prevalent and where migrants who report discrimination exhibit higher levels of political voice.*

To understand when and how societal demands successfully reshape legislative behaviour, we must examine the intersection of internal elite motivation and external civic signals. Policy elites are not passive, uniform recipients of societal inputs; they must interpret who the claimants are and evaluate the legitimacy of their demands (Skrentny, 2006). This interpretative step is where the interaction between descriptive background and external claims-making becomes critical.

We argue that the relationship between external civic claim-making pressure and institutional attention is conditional, varying systematically by the descriptive background of the MEP. While high-visibility mobilisation sends an informational signal to all legislators, MEPs with a migratory background possess a unique capacity and strategic incentive to decode and amplify these specific demands. Conceptually, claims-making is a relational process of recognition (Bloemraad, 2017). Minority-background representatives, by virtue of their experiential and network-based ties to marginalised communities, are uniquely positioned to view localised, discrimination-based protests or petitions as credible and electorally salient signals rather than peripheral noise.

Furthermore, these elites face distinct reputational incentives; their standing as credible representatives within mixed electorates often relies on their ability to act as institutional conduits for minority grievances (Bajpai, 2019; Saalfeld & Bischof, 2013). Therefore, while a highly vocal, discriminated constituency may exert a modest pressure on all representatives, it will find its most potent expression when interacting with the receptive internal gyroscope of a minority-background legislator.

H3: *The relationship between political engagement among migrants who report discrimination and MEP attention to discrimination-related issues is expected to be stronger among MEPs with a migratory background.*

Data and measurements

The empirical investigation draws on three complementary data sources: individual-level survey data from the European Social Survey (ESS) Rounds 1–11 (2002–2024), data derived from the EUQuest Project on the policy content of Questions for Written Answers in the European Parliament, and data on the migratory background of MEPs sitting in the 8th and 9th legislatures (2014–2024). Together, these sources enable us to (1) capture cross-national variation in migrants’

discrimination-related grievances and their translation into political voice, and (2) assess whether Members of the European Parliament (MEPs) with a migratory background adjust their issue emphasis in response to this “claims-making pressure”.

Measuring attention to ethnic discrimination in the European Parliament

To map the substantive legislative behavior of MEPs, we utilize parliamentary written questions. Following process-oriented models of parliamentary representation (Mügge et al., 2019), written questions serve as an optimal metric of individual representative intent because they face lower institutional veto barriers and are significantly less constrained by Europarty group discipline than legislative voting records (Russo & Wiberg, 2010). We isolate attention to discrimination by extracting questions classified under topic-code 201 ("Ethnic Minority and Racial Group Discrimination") of the Comparative Agendas Project (CAP) coding scheme. While immigration-related policy (CAP code 900) is highly polarized and frequently weaponized by far-right actors to restrict minority rights, subtopic 201 functions predominantly as a valence issue within the European Parliament. Content under this code focuses on equal treatment, protection from bias, and civil rights enforcement. Utilizing this subtopic minimizes the risk of false positives—instances where a high issue volume signifies hostile anti-immigrant salience rather than protective advocacy.

As shown in our sample, text meeting this criteria is highly specialized: code 201 accounts for roughly 1.1% of all written questions across both terms, yielding questions in the 8th EP and questions in the 9th EP. Rather than being driven by a handful of outliers, this agenda-setting behavior is distributed across 225 individual MEPs in the 8th legislature and 124 in the 9th. We operationalize this dependent variable in two ways for robustness: (i) as a binary indicator for whether an MEP submitted at least one question under code 201 during the legislative term, and (ii) as a count variable of total code 201 questions submitted.

Measuring MEPs' migratory background

For the purpose of this study, we are interested in individuating MEPs who either have a migratory background or are part of a racialised minority. Migratory background is operationalised as being either a first- or second-generation migrant from an extra-EU country which is not in the Global North. The European Union does not gather data on the migratory or ethnic background of the MEPs. The only available data is the place of birth, whose relation with migratory background is both incomplete and potentially misleading. The European Network Against Racism (ENAR) recently published a report (ENAR 2024) on the evolution of different dimensions of diversity in the 2014 and 2019 European elections. The report's rationale is that diversity across gender, ethnic origin, sexual orientation, and disability enhances the legitimacy of the European Parliament. Much attention is dedicated to the presence of MEPs from “racialized minorities,” who are defined as those MEPs who “either identify as non-white or identify as belonging (also) to a non-EU country that is not in the Global North, or both” (ENAR 2024, 54). Based on this definition, the report described a slight increase in the number of racialized representatives, who comprised 3.3% of all MEPs in the 8th EP (28 out of 860) and 4.5% in the 9th mandate (39 out of 874, before the exit of the UK). Unfortunately, the ENAR does not provide individual data on MEPs, but only presents aggregate statistics.

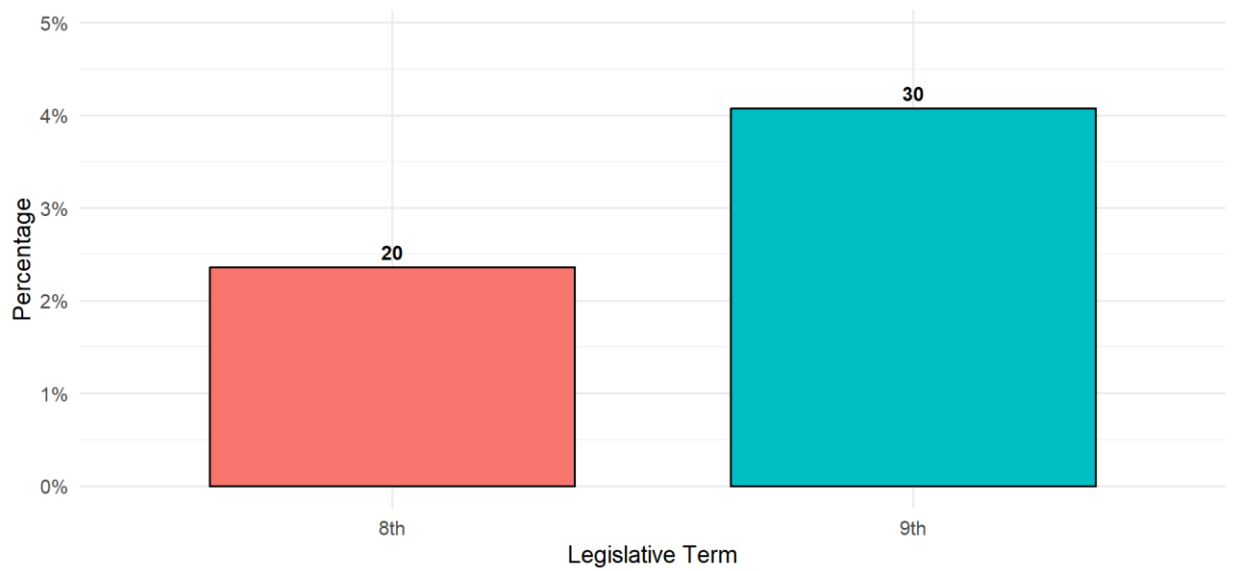


Figure 1. MEPs with a migratory background by legislature

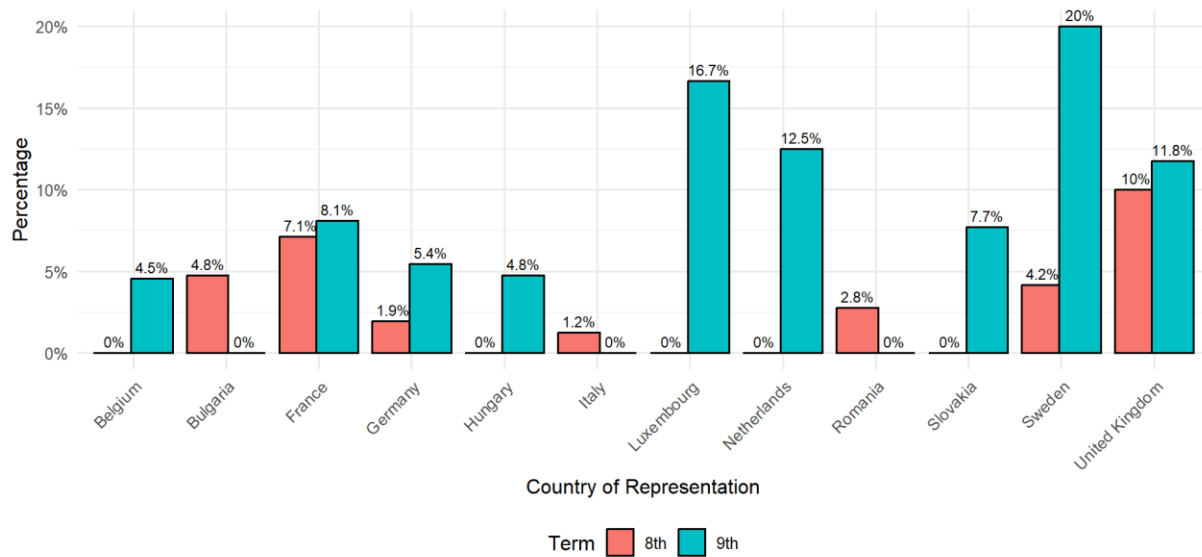


Figure 2. Percentage of MEPs with a migratory background by country

Original biographical research conducted for this work resulted in finding only 20 MEPs with a migratory background in the 8th and 30 in the 9th (see [Figure 3](#)). This figure also includes members identifying as Romani: despite the vast majority of them having no or remote migratory descent, the Roma are subject to widespread discrimination according to the European Union Agency for Fundamental Rights. In empirical terms, there should be an almost perfect overlap between the MEPs identified by ENAR (ENAR 2024) and those who are the object of this study. More precisely, our definition is slightly broader and may have resulted in a slightly higher count. On the contrary, our figures are slightly lower. As ENAR does not list the names of the MEPs included in their report, it has not been possible to conduct a detailed comparison. However, our data also confirm that the EP emerging from the 2019 election was more diverse than its predecessor. The countries contributing more to the descriptive representation of migrants and racialised minorities were the UK and France, respectively, with 8 and 6 elected in both legislative periods. In the 9th legislature, a significant number of MEPs with a migratory background also came from Germany (5), Sweden (4) and the Netherlands (3).

Measuring Claim Making Pressure

To construct our contextual macro-level signal, we aggregate individual-level response data from the pooled ESS Rounds 1–11 (2002–2024) across 26 EU Member States and the United Kingdom. We identify a respondent's migratory background through parental countries of birth, yielding a pooled sample of 28,996 first-generation and 9,029 second-generation migrants.

Our main contextual variable, Claims-Making Pressure, captures the structural availability of a vocal, aggrieved constituency within an MEP's home member state. We build this variable via a two-stage aggregation:

1. **Perceived Ethnic Discrimination:** We compute the survey-weighted percentage of migrants within the country who report belonging to a group discriminated against on migration-relevant grounds (ethnicity, nationality, race, language, or religion).
2. **Active Migrants:** It is the survey-weighted percentage of migrants who report political action in the last 12 months
3. **Claim Making Pressure:** We isolate the subset of migrants who both report this discrimination *and* report engaging in at least one non-electoral act of political voice (contacting an official, signing a petition, demonstrating, or posting political content online) within the preceding 12 months.

Table 1 shows notable cross-national variation in self-reported migration-relevant discrimination among migrants, based on whether respondents report belonging to a group that is discriminated against in the country on grounds commonly linked to migrant status (ethnicity, nationality, race/colour, language, religion). The prevalence of reported discrimination varies markedly across countries. It is highest in Greece (46%), and comparatively high in the Netherlands (30%), Latvia (26%), Italy (27%), France (27%), and Austria (25%), indicating contexts where migrants more frequently report discrimination on these grounds. By contrast, reported discrimination is comparatively low in Hungary (4%), Croatia (5%), Slovenia (6%), and Lithuania (8%). Estimate precision also differs across countries, reflecting variation in ESS migrant sample sizes: standard errors and confidence intervals are relatively small where migrant samples are larger (e.g., Germany, France, the Netherlands) and wider where migrant subsamples are small (e.g., Slovakia, Bulgaria, Poland). Notably, several long-standing migrant destination contexts such as Germany, France, the Netherlands, and the UK also exhibit mid-to-high levels of reported migration-relevant discrimination (roughly one-fifth to one-third of migrants), suggesting

that perceived discrimination remains salient even in countries with established immigrant populations.

Subsequently, the second component is operationalised as a contextual measure of claims-making pressure among migrants, defined as the weighted percentage of migrants who both report migration-relevant discrimination and report political action (i.e., $100 \times P(D = 1 \& A = 1 \mid \text{migrant}, c)$). This joint measure varies substantially across countries, ranging from very low levels in Czechia and Croatia (around 1.5%) to comparatively high levels in the Netherlands (15%), the United Kingdom (15%), Sweden (12%), France (13%), and Germany (11%). Descriptively, these patterns identify contexts where discrimination-related grievances are more frequently accompanied by observable political action among migrants, versus contexts where the overlap between discrimination experiences and political action is comparatively limited.

Table 1. Migration-relevant discrimination and claims-making pressure among migrants, by country (ESS Rounds 1–11, 2002–2024)

Country	Discrimination among migrants (%)	SE	95% CI	Claims- making pressure among migrants (%)	SE	95% CI
Austria	25.45	2.08	[21.60, 29.74]	10.42	1.44	[7.60, 13.24]
Belgium	17.12	1.66	[14.11, 20.63]	7.83	1.02	[5.83, 9.83]
Bulgaria	8.71	4.31	[3.19, 21.62]	2.25	2.24	[-2.14, 6.65]
Cyprus	16.82	3.75	[10.68, 25.48]	8.44	3.00	[2.55, 14.32]
Czechia	22.29	4.98	[14.03, 33.50]	1.35	0.82	[-0.26, 2.96]
Germany	23.69	1.40	[21.06, 26.53]	11.18	1.01	[9.20, 13.16]
Denmark	19.91	4.60	[12.37, 30.45]	10.96	3.54	[4.02, 17.91]
Estonia	18.02	1.39	[15.46, 20.89]	6.08	0.86	[4.39, 7.77]
Spain	16.74	1.53	[13.95, 19.96]	7.14	0.99	[5.20, 9.08]
Finland	19.56	3.61	[13.42, 27.60]	11.55	2.82	[6.03, 17.07]
France	27.27	1.89	[23.73, 31.12]	13.03	1.30	[10.48, 15.58]
United Kingdom	22.16	2.00	[18.48, 26.33]	14.91	1.70	[11.59, 18.24]
Greece	46.24	4.98	[36.74, 56.02]	7.65	2.72	[2.32, 12.98]
Croatia	4.70	0.93	[3.18, 6.90]	1.42	0.51	[0.42, 2.42]
Hungary	4.27	2.19	[1.54, 11.30]	n.a.	n.a.	n.a.
Ireland	13.36	1.56	[10.59, 16.72]	4.77	0.94	[2.94, 6.61]
Italy	26.73	2.38	[22.34, 31.64]	5.72	1.00	[3.75, 7.69]
Lithuania	8.15	2.51	[4.40, 14.60]	5.75	2.14	[1.55, 9.94]
Latvia	26.45	2.59	[21.70, 31.81]	9.73	1.77	[6.26, 13.20]

Country	Discrimination among migrants (%)	SE	95% CI	Claims- making pressure among migrants (%)	SE	95% CI
Netherlands	29.89	2.13	[25.90, 34.22]	15.11	1.67	[11.84, 18.38]
Poland	10.11	4.36	[4.21, 22.35]	4.02	2.80	[-1.46, 9.50]
Portugal	21.16	2.43	[16.79, 26.32]	5.59	1.15	[3.34, 7.83]
Sweden	18.59	1.68	[15.52, 22.10]	12.38	1.43	[9.57, 15.19]
Slovenia	6.26	1.21	[4.27, 9.09]	3.12	0.89	[1.36, 4.87]
Slovakia	9.10	8.49	[1.32, 42.79]	n.a.	n.a.	n.a.

Notes: Survey-weighted estimates (ESS post-stratification weight). SE = standard error. “Discrimination among migrants” is the weighted percentage of migrants reporting belonging to a group discriminated against on migration-relevant grounds (ethnicity, nationality, race/colour, language, religion). “Claims-making pressure among migrants” is the weighted percentage of migrants who both report migration-relevant discrimination and report political action. “n.a.” indicates that the estimate is not reported where the country-specific migrant/discriminated subsample is too small or yields insufficient variation for a stable estimate.

Because the ESS does not explicitly link a respondent's political action to their experience of discrimination, we do not interpret this measure as a direct tally of discrimination-specific mobilization. Instead, it serves as a macro-level indicator of the civic capacity and visibility of the discriminated population. Where this joint intersection is high, grievances are structurally positioned to spill over into the public sphere, creating an ambient informational signal that reaches domestic political elites. This metric successfully uncovers vast cross-national variance. As illustrated in Figure X, while structural discrimination is exceptionally high in Greece, its active claims-making pressure is muted. Conversely, countries like the United Kingdom, the Netherlands, and France combine high baseline discrimination with highly vocal migrant populations, creating a loud signal that we hypothesize will uniquely activate descriptive MEPs.

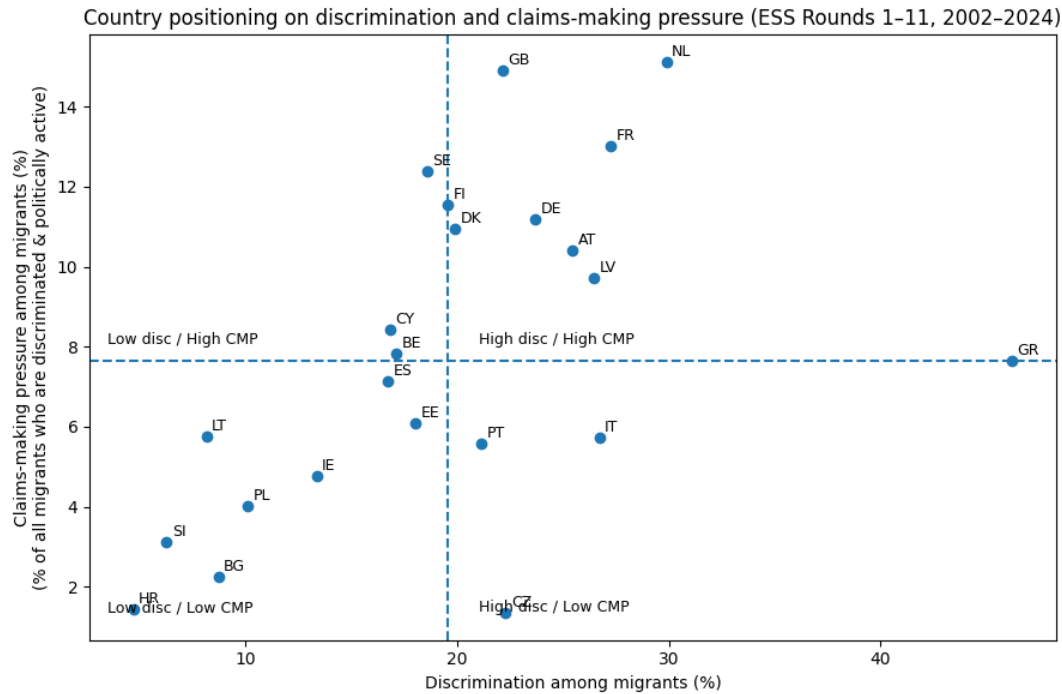


Figure 3. Cross-national variation in migration-relevant discrimination and claims-making pressure among migrants (ESS Rounds 1–11, 2002–2024)

Empirical Strategy

To test our hypotheses regarding the internal and external drivers of legislative issue attention, we estimate a series of multilevel regression models. The dependent variable, the number of questions asked on Subtopic 201, represents the total count of written parliamentary questions tabled by an individual Member of the European Parliament (MEP) on ethnic and racial discrimination within a given year. Modelling this outcome poses two significant distributional challenges common in legislative studies: an overabundance of zeros (as most MEPs do not ask a question on this niche topic in a given year) and a highly skewed count distribution among active legislators.

To address these properties, we employ Zero-Inflated Negative Binomial (ZINB) Generalized Linear Mixed Models (GLMM) via the `glmmTMB` package in R. The ZINB architecture handles the data generation process as a dual-stage mixture model:

1. **The Zero-Inflation Stage:** A logistic regression component models the structural propensity of an observation to be a "zero", in our context, identifying the structural barriers or systemic lack of opportunity that prevents an MEP from ever engaging with subtopic 201 during the observation window.
2. **The Conditional Count Stage:** A negative binomial regression component estimates the rate of question generation among MEPs who cross the initial exposure threshold, effectively accounting for overdispersion where the variance of the question counts exceeds the mean.

Our analytical framework necessitates accounting for the complex hierarchical structure of our data, where observations are nested within individual legislators over time, who are in turn

nested within their respective country delegations. We therefore specify a multi-level random-intercept architecture with crossed random effects: a random intercept for the individual legislator to control for unobserved time-invariant individual traits, and a random intercept for the country to account for baseline national legislative cultures and unobserved specificities.

To adjust for the reality that some MEPs are generally more active than others, we include an exposure variable: the natural log of total written questions asked by that MEP plus an offset constant, specified as $\text{offset}(\log(\text{total_questions} + 1))$. This ensures that our estimates reflect an MEP's proportional *attention* to anti-discrimination relative to their overall legislative output, rather than reflecting raw legislative volume.

Along our main independent variables, having a migratory background and the Claim Making Pressure, some individual-level control variables have been added to all our models, including MEPs' gender, party group political family, and membership in the LIBE committee that is responsible for anti-discrimination policies. At the country level, we included the raw indicator of perceived ethnic discrimination among migrants, a composite indicator of the economic situation called the Misery Index (see Borghetto and Russo 2018), and a macro-geographical distinction between European regions.

Results and Discussion

To systematically assess the structural and experiential determinants of parliamentary attention, we built our modelling framework sequentially from a baseline contextual model to our fully interactive specification.

Model 1 evaluates purely environmental and macroeconomic determinants alongside a robust battery of individual and institutional controls, including MEP gender, European geographic region, party family, and membership in the Civil Liberties, Justice and Home Affairs (LIBE) committee.

Model 2 introduces our measure of descriptive representation, isolating the baseline effect of an MEP's migratory or racialized background while omitting mass-level indicators.

Model 3 combines both internal descriptive traits and external mass-level signals.

Model 4 introduces a multiplicative interaction term to explicitly test whether descriptive representatives show heightened strategic sensitivity to vocal, aggrieved home constituencies.

Table 2. Zero-Inflated Negative Binomial Regression Predicting Questions on Ethnic Discrimination (Coefficients are IRR)

	Model 1	Model 2	Model 3	Model 4
(Intercept)	0.008 [0.00, 0.02]***	0.006 [0.00, 0.01]***	0.007 [0.00, 0.01]***	0.007 [0.00, 0.01]***
Gender: Male	1.018 [0.79, 1.32]	1.047 [0.81, 1.35]	1.033 [0.80, 1.33]	1.034 [0.80, 1.33]
Geographic_region: Northern	0.572 [0.28, 1.15]	0.776 [0.50, 1.20]	0.580 [0.29, 1.15]	0.579 [0.29, 1.15]
Geographic_region: Southern	0.791 [0.47, 1.34]	0.736 [0.49, 1.11]	0.828 [0.49, 1.39]	0.827 [0.49, 1.39]
Geographic_region: Western	0.438 [0.22, 0.87]*	0.537 [0.36, 0.79]**	0.464 [0.24, 0.91]*	0.462 [0.23, 0.91]*
Misery_index	0.992 [0.97, 1.01]	0.998 [0.98, 1.02]	0.993 [0.97, 1.01]	0.993 [0.97, 1.01]
Party_family: Communists and socialists	1.268 [0.78, 2.07]	1.284 [0.80, 2.06]	1.236 [0.77, 1.99]	1.236 [0.77, 1.99]
Party_family: Eurosceptic conservatives	0.859 [0.51, 1.44]	0.889 [0.53, 1.48]	0.850 [0.51, 1.42]	0.850 [0.51, 1.42]
Party_family: Eurosceptics	1.101 [0.58, 2.08]	1.153 [0.63, 2.13]	1.168 [0.62, 2.19]	1.166 [0.62, 2.18]
Party_family: Greens/EFA	1.373 [0.81, 2.34]	1.391 [0.83, 2.34]	1.346 [0.80, 2.27]	1.344 [0.80, 2.27]
Party_family: Liberals	1.165 [0.73, 1.86]	1.188 [0.75, 1.88]	1.145 [0.72, 1.81]	1.145 [0.72, 1.81]
Party_family: NI	1.343 [0.74, 2.45]	1.349 [0.75, 2.43]	1.422 [0.78, 2.58]	1.422 [0.78, 2.58]
Party_family: Right-wing nationalists	1.979 [1.27, 3.09]**	1.944 [1.27, 2.98]**	2.059 [1.33, 3.19]**	2.058 [1.33, 3.19]**
Party_family: Social democrats	1.217 [0.82, 1.81]	1.187 [0.80, 1.76]	1.153 [0.78, 1.71]	1.153 [0.78, 1.71]
Committee: LIBE	1.656 [1.11, 2.47]*	1.501 [1.00, 2.24]*	1.503 [1.01, 2.24]*	1.499 [1.00, 2.24]*
CMP	1.074 [1.00, 1.15]*	NA	1.061 [0.99, 1.13].	1.061 [0.99, 1.13].
Discrimination	0.976 [0.94, 1.01]	NA	0.973 [0.94, 1.00].	0.974 [0.94, 1.00].
Migratory background (Minority)	NA	3.467 [1.87, 6.44]***	3.433 [1.84, 6.40]***	3.621 [1.29, 10.20]*
Minority*CMP	NA	NA	NA	0.986 [0.79, 1.24]

Model performance was evaluated following the empirical criteria indicated by Lüdecke et al. (2021), averaging the normalised version of several performance indicators of Fit and Information Criteria. Table X shows the main ones, the predictive error (RMSE) alongside Akaike and Bayesian Information Criteria (AIC/BIC) weights. While Model 2 achieves the highest parsimony under strict sample penalties, Model 3 provides the most statistically robust fit when incorporating national contextual factors, yielding the highest overall evaluation score of 69.3%. Crucially, the addition of the multiplicative interaction term in Model 4 fails to introduce any additional explanatory value, resulting in a precipitous drop in the model's performance score to 39.3%.

Table 3. *Model performance metrics*

Model	RMSE	AIC Weight	BIC Weight	Overall Score
M3: Fully Controlled + Country RE	0.308	0.455	0.001	69.3%
M2: Adding Minority Predictor	0.308	0.375	0.998	66.5%
M4: Country RE + Interaction	0.308	0.169	0.000	39.3%
M1: Baseline Individual Controls	0.303	0.001	0.000	38.7%

Likelihood ratio test comparisons (ANOVA) confirm that adding the joint mass and elite vectors in Model 3 yields a highly significant improvement in explanatory power over both Model 1 and Model 2 ($p < 0.05$). Crucially, the transition to Model 4, incorporating the multiplicative interaction term, fails to yield any statistically significant improvement in model fit or change in log-likelihood. This empirical pattern delivers a clear, foundational diagnostic for our theoretical framework: the internal engine of descriptive representation and the external engine of civic claims-making pressure operate as structurally independent forces.

Testing Hypothesis 1: The Descriptive Engine

Our first hypothesis anticipated that MEPs with a migratory or racialized minority background would exhibit a significantly higher baseline propensity to table parliamentary questions regarding ethnic discrimination. The conditional count estimates from our winning specification (Model 3) offer robust empirical confirmation for this expectation. Holding all institutional, committee, partisan, and national macroeconomic factors constant, the coefficient for minority is positive, substantial, and statistically significant.

When exponentiated to derive Incident Rate Ratios (IRR), the results demonstrate that belonging to a migratory or racialised minority background acts as a powerful internal catalyst for agenda-setting, drastically increasing the expected count of anti-discrimination questions relative to majority-background counterparts. This finding validates the "personal roots of representation" framework: even within a highly institutionalized, transnational assembly where Europarty group

discipline is formidable, individual biographical traits remain highly predictive of substantive legislative behavior.

Testing Hypothesis 2: The Informational Signal of Civic Pressure

Our second hypothesis (H2) posited that external, mass-level claims-making pressure, the strategic intersection of widespread experienced discrimination and vocal political action among migrants at the country level, would exert a positive informational pull on MEP behaviour. Model 3 provides empirical confirmation for this dynamic. The claims-making pressure variable displays a positive effect on the rate of question submission, although the coefficient achieves only a marginally statistically significant level.

When marginalized populations successfully externalize their grievances through localized political actions (such as signing petitions, participating in demonstrations, or contacting officials), they create a visible public signal. This signal successfully penetrates the transnational legislative arena, lowering diagnostic costs and prompting domestic MEPs to elevate these concerns into formal parliamentary questions. Notably, this effect holds even when controlling for baseline national discrimination levels and national economic conditions, demonstrating that it is the *politicisation and visibility* of the grievance via collective action, not merely its structural existence, that drives agenda-setting.

Testing Hypothesis 3: The Interaction Paradox

Finally, our third hypothesis anticipated an interaction effect, where minority-background MEPs would show unique sensitivity or heightened responsiveness to the claims-making pressures emanating from their home countries. The empirical results definitively refute this expectation.

As established by the model selection metrics and the non-significant interaction coefficient in Model 4, the two effects are entirely independent. The strategic interaction model does not explain the variance any better than the additive main-effects model.

This structural independence reveals what we conceptualise as the separate channels of representation in the European Parliament:

- Minority-background MEPs do not require a loud, highly vocal domestic signal to prompt them into action; their internal, experiential motivation provides a baseline dedication to civil rights issues that operates continuously, regardless of whether their home constituencies are currently mobilised or quiet.
- Conversely, the modest positive pull of civic claims-making pressure applies universally across the legislative spectrum, influencing majority and minority representatives alike due to shared electoral or informational incentives.

By demonstrating that descriptive representation and civic mobilisation function as potent but parallel tracks, our analysis provides a nuanced corrective to traditional democratic

responsiveness loops, revealing that elite biographical advocacy and grassroots minority activism operate alongside, rather than in direct synergy with one another.

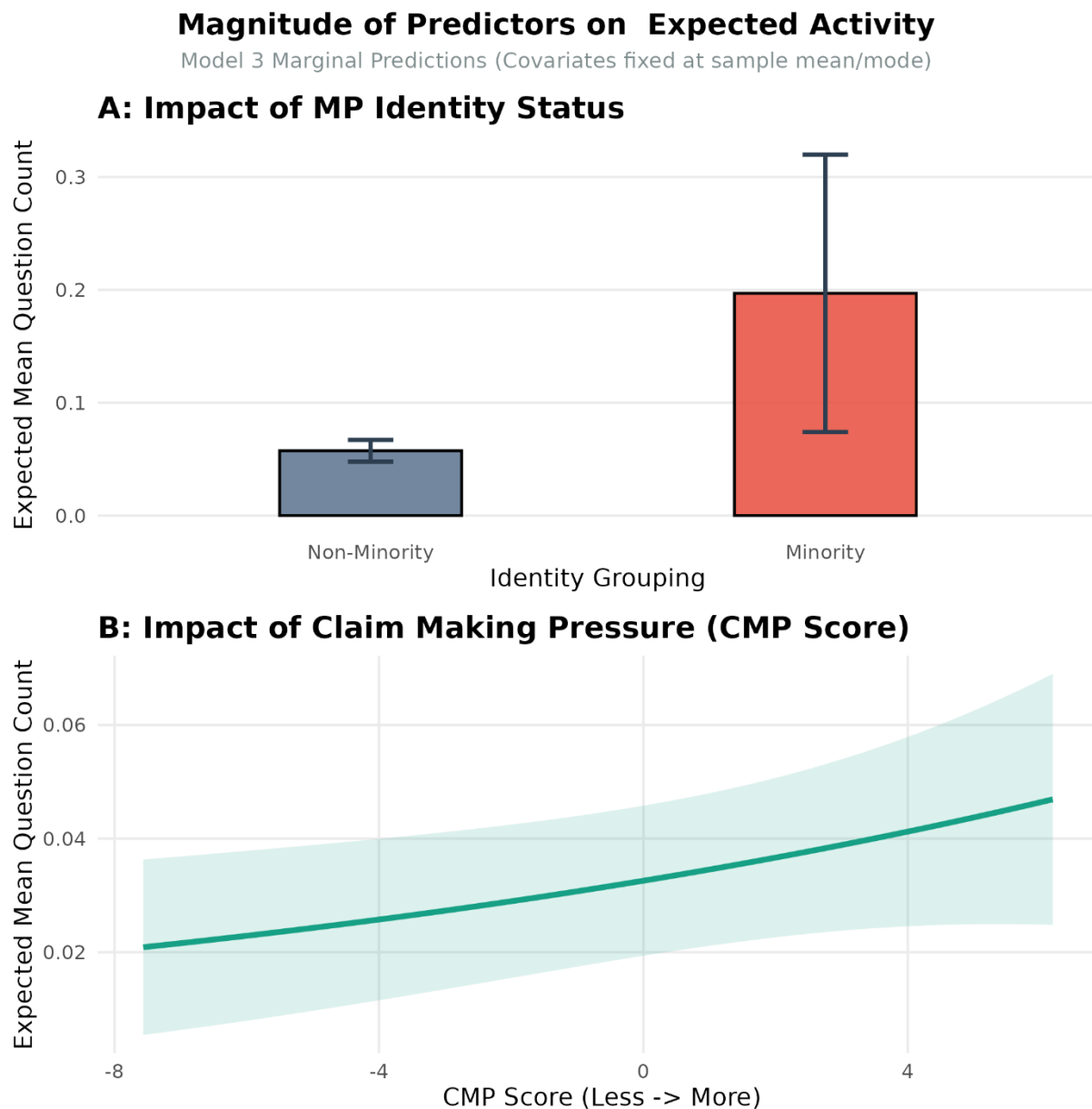


Figure 4. Magnitude of Effects

Limitations and Next Steps

This section outlines the limitations of our current analytical framework and maps out the immediate steps planned to refine the paper in the next steps. Three main areas need action, in descending order of priority.

A core conceptual pillar of our empirical strategy was the choice of the Comparative Agendas Project (CAP) subtopic 201 ("Ethnic Minority and Racial Group Discrimination"). We theoretically assumed that by isolating this subtopic, rather than broader immigration policies, we were capturing a pure "valence issue" centred on protective civil rights enforcement, thereby minimising the risk of capturing hostile, anti-immigrant rhetoric. However, our empirical estimates challenge this clean conceptual boundary. Across all four models, the variable for Right-Wing Nationalist party families yields a positive, substantial, and highly statistically significant effect on the rate of question submission. Far-right legislators are tabbing questions on ethnic discrimination at double the rate of the baseline category. This surprising finding signals a critical limitation and suggests two potential realities that alter how we must interpret our dependent variable.

To resolve this paradox, we plan to execute a qualitative content analysis or structural topic model (STM) on the underlying text of the written questions submitted by right-wing nationalist MEPs. We need to distinguish genuine protective advocacy from restrictive or adversarial framing. We welcome suggestions on how best to systematically filter out positional issue-hijacking within a quantitative count framework.

A second structural limitation resides in the temporal specification of our primary mass-level independent variable. Currently, our Claims-Making Pressure (CMP) indicator is calculated as a pooled, time-invariant country-level mean spanning the entirety of the ESS dataset (Rounds 1-11). While this effectively maps structural cross-national variation, it treats the mass-level environment as a static state-level characteristic. In reality, both experienced migration-relevant discrimination and the propensity for collective action fluctuate within countries over time in response to shifting domestic electoral cycles, legislative changes, and macro-shocks (such as the 2015 refugee crisis or the mobilisation of the Black Lives Matter movement). By using a time-invariant proxy, our models cannot capture whether an MEP's issue entrepreneurial behaviour shifts dynamically in response to localised spikes or drops in domestic constituency pressure. We are currently auditing the ESS sample sizes to determine if we can safely de-pool the data and calculate round-specific or year-specific CMP metrics without inducing severe small-sample bias within smaller member state delegations. Transitioning to a truly longitudinal, time-varying contextual predictor will allow us to include country-specific fixed effects or time-trends, radically strengthening our causal claims and more effectively ruling out unobserved national confounders.

Finally, our elite-level biographical dataset is currently limited to the 8th and 9th European Parliaments (2014–2024). While these terms capture a crucial era marked by heightened diversity and rising political polarisation, restricting the data to this ten-year window limits our statistical power. Because the absolute baseline number of MEPs with a verified migratory or racialised minority background is low, our interaction terms in Model 4 suffer from wide standard errors, potentially obscuring a subtle relational effect. To maximise the empirical leverage of this paper, we are launching an expanded round of archival and biographical research to map the migratory and minority status of MEPs retroactively through the 6th and 7th legislatures (2004–2014). Extending our tracking to a twenty-year horizon will substantially expand our sample size of descriptive representatives, giving our models the statistical power needed to definitively test for interaction effects.

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